

23 WEEKS Keeping active means you will be well prepared for the birth, and primed for a rapid recovery.



Baby watch

📏 12 in (30 cm) 📖 1 lb 5 oz (600 g)

Your baby's lungs start to produce a substance called surfactant now, which supports the tiny air sacs (alveoli) in the lungs, strengthening them in preparation for breathing outside of the uterus. In the inner ear, the cochlea is fully developed and allows hearing. Your baby may startle at loud noises and turn her head in response to sounds. She is also becoming familiar with your voice, which she'll recognize at birth.

Mom matters

Regular gentle exercise will help to keep your muscles and ligaments strong and supple. This will also help to relieve pregnancy complaints such as backaches. There's also some evidence that women who exercise have a shorter labor, and that the fetal heartbeat is stronger. Kegel exercises are very important too, helping to strengthen the hammock of muscles that support the pelvic area and organs, including the uterus.



This week...

» If you haven't already done so, think about how to tell an older child about the baby's arrival. A young child may have little concept of timings, though, so keep explanations simple. There are also books you can use to introduce the idea.

» Good sources of protein such as lean meat, legumes, eggs, and cheese are essential for the healthy growth of your baby.

24 WEEKS Your baby might be active when you want to sleep—kicking, yawning, and even hiccupping.



Baby watch

📏 13½ in (34.6 cm) 📖 1 lb 8 oz (660 g)

Your baby is starting to develop a primitive memory as the brain becomes more complex, and brain waves now are similar to those of a newborn's. You may notice your baby's hiccups now, and your baby may yawn as she develops a cycle of sleeping and waking. The nostrils are open, and the adult teeth buds are developing in the gums. By the end of this trimester, the fetal heartbeat has slowed to 140–150 beats a minute.

Mom matters

You will notice your abdomen expanding quickly as it stretches to accommodate your rapidly growing baby. As your belly protrudes outward and rises, it presses on your diaphragm, and you may feel breathless. It also nudges against your stomach, which can lead to heartburn and acid reflux.



This week...

» As your belly gets bigger, you may feel off-balance. Be aware of compensating for this with bad posture that puts an additional strain on your back.

» You may have to shift the position that you sleep in as your belly continues to grow larger. If you tend to sleep on your stomach, that may no longer be an option. Sleeping on your back doesn't allow for the best blood flow to your baby; try sleeping on your side. Either is fine, but the left side is recommended.

25 WEEKS At the close of the second trimester, your thoughts might turn to the birth.



Baby watch

📏 14 in (35.6 cm) 📖 1 lb 10¼ oz (760 g)

With fully formed hands, your baby can grasp anything she comes into contact with. She may have discovered the pleasure of thumb-sucking. There's still room in the uterus for quite a bit of movement; some babies make a pedaling motion akin to walking. In boys, the testes start to move down from the lower abdomen into the scrotum.

Mom matters

Your uterus continues to move upward. Your organs are compressed by the expanding uterus, and you could feel a bit cramped inside. Blood volume has increased to around 8¾ pints (5 liters), and your heart is working hard to pump it around. The blood vessels have relaxed as much as possible, so your blood pressure may rise a little now. It is normal for your hands, feet, and ankles to swell as a result of fluid retention (edema). Severe swelling will need to be monitored.



This week...

» You may have a prenatal appointment this week. The doctor will measure the height of your uterus (the fundus) to check that your baby is growing as expected.

» If you have had a previous late miscarriage, you may be given an ultrasound now to check the length of your cervix.

» As your digestive system is squashed, it may be easier to eat smaller, more frequent meals instead of the usual three large meals.